

Tech it easy!

Just a few years ago, if you'd asked me about a digital detox, I'd have imagined something close to a vanishing act of tech-free retreats in remote cabins or meditative escapes in disconnected sanctuaries. In my mind, it was simple: escape technology to find some much needed peace and calm. But here in 2024, as a father to a 10-year-old who navigates tech as deftly as playgrounds, I've come to understand that the concept of a digital detox needs a serious rethink.

The idea of a digital detox isn't new. It has been steadily gaining traction, but the pandemic years definitely made it more prominent. Just in the early 2020s, we often talked about 'unplugging' as the ultimate remedy to our digital woes. Statistics from that era painted a grim picture, since many professionals found themselves to be "almost constantly" online – including yours truly. Anxiety, sleep disruption, and a decrease in physical activity were the tolls paid for our always-online lifestyle (dictated by "WFH"). It seemed logical then to think the only escape was to cut ourselves off completely from any and all kinds of digital devices, right?

However, as I've realised, life and technology aren't quite that black and white. My evolution in thinking mirrors a broader, more nuanced understanding of what it means to coexist healthily with technology. Digital detox can never mean completely shutting ourselves off from technology, not unless you want to live in a society that's constantly finding ways to digitise the un-digitised. It's about integrating technology in healthier ways. This shift in perspective is crucial in a world where digital natives, like my daughter, will navigate a landscape we can barely imagine.

A 2021 Harvard study demonstrated that rather than abstaining from digital devices altogether, moderated and mindful use significantly reduced stress and improved mental well-being. It suggested that the quality of our digital interactions matters more than the quantity. How you use tech products or how much time you allow yourself to spend on digital devices is more important than having a fully no-tech lifestyle.

Let's face it, the pandemic years have shown us that technology can be a lifeline – connecting us with loved ones, enabling remote work, and



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offering educational tools that transform how our children learn. So, the goal isn't to revert to a pre-digital era – it's unrealistic and, frankly, undesirable. Instead, the focus should be on creating intentional boundaries that allow us to harness the benefits of technology while mitigating its more damaging impacts.

This personal realisation hit home recently one evening as I watched my daughter seamlessly toggle between homework on a document editor, a virtual dance class, and chatting with her grandparents via video – all in the span of an hour. The integration of technology in her life was with clear purpose, yet there was a clear boundary with rationed screen time or when dinner rolled around, and all screens had to be turned off. The aim was to have a harmonious balance that allowed for both connectivity and meaningful family interaction.

Adopting a more disciplined approach to technology use means setting specific times when devices are welcome and times when they aren't. For instance, no phones at the dinner table or turning off notifications after a certain hour to ensure that our devices don't keep us from sleeping soundly. I've started reading books at bed time – the good old fashioned paper books. Moreover, engaging with technology also means choosing quality over quantity. This means prioritising meaningful digital interactions over passive consumption. No doomscrolling social media feeds or swiping through endless amounts of IG Reels. It's about building a pattern of your diminished digital indulgence to form a healthy habit towards a balanced lifestyle.

In this redefined vision of a digital detox, we have to accept that technology is an integral part of our lives, but we also reclaim control over how and when it permeates our daily routines. This isn't a detox in the traditional sense; it's a recalibration, a way to ensure that our interactions with digital devices are intentional, meaningful, and, most importantly, within limits that we set on ourselves. Embracing this balanced approach will be essential and crucial. We aren't stepping back into the dark ages but stepping forward into a world where technology serves us, enriching our lives without overwhelming them. This is the detox we all deserve! **d**